

The Signaling Gap:

State-Owned Media and the Strategic Management of Sentiment during the Russian Invasion of Ukraine

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Political Science



Photo: REUTERS/Carlos Barria February 24, 2022

The Bind

Your treaty ally just invaded
a sovereign state.

You can't condemn them —
they guarantee your
security.

You can't stay silent — the
West is watching.



Photo: UN Photo/Mark Garten February, 25 2022

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The Hidden Channel



We think state media is for the masses. The CIA thinks it's for them.

The Gap

Academics

- Agenda setting & framing
- Spin dictators & censorship
- Domestic opinion formation

Practitioners

- Window into regime preferences
- Shifts in tone = policy signals
- 80+ years of institutional practice

We formalize what practitioners have known

Why the Signal Works

Readable

Everyone knows state media is state-controlled. Deviation is informative.

Costly

Negative coverage of your patron risks retaliation from Moscow.

Deniable

"We don't control the press." Institutional separation protects the relationship.

Data & Design

174K

Articles

11 countries, 62 sources

GPT-4o

Sentiment

F1 = .92 vs. human coders

RD

In Time

Feb, 24 2022 as cutoff

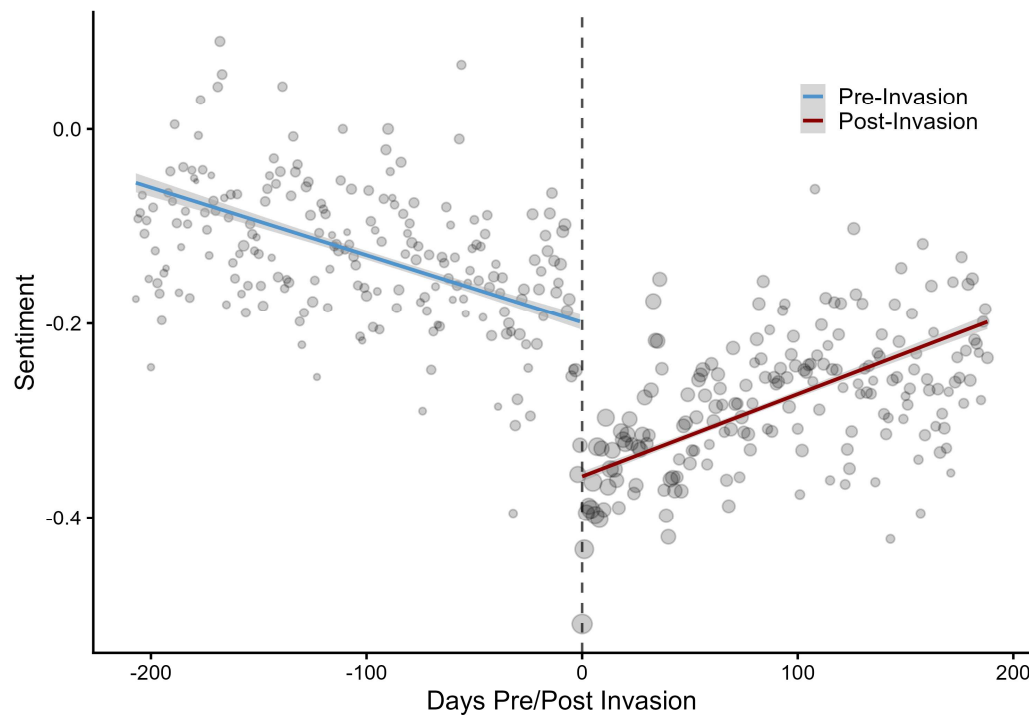
3

Groups

Russia-aligned, Neutral, NATO

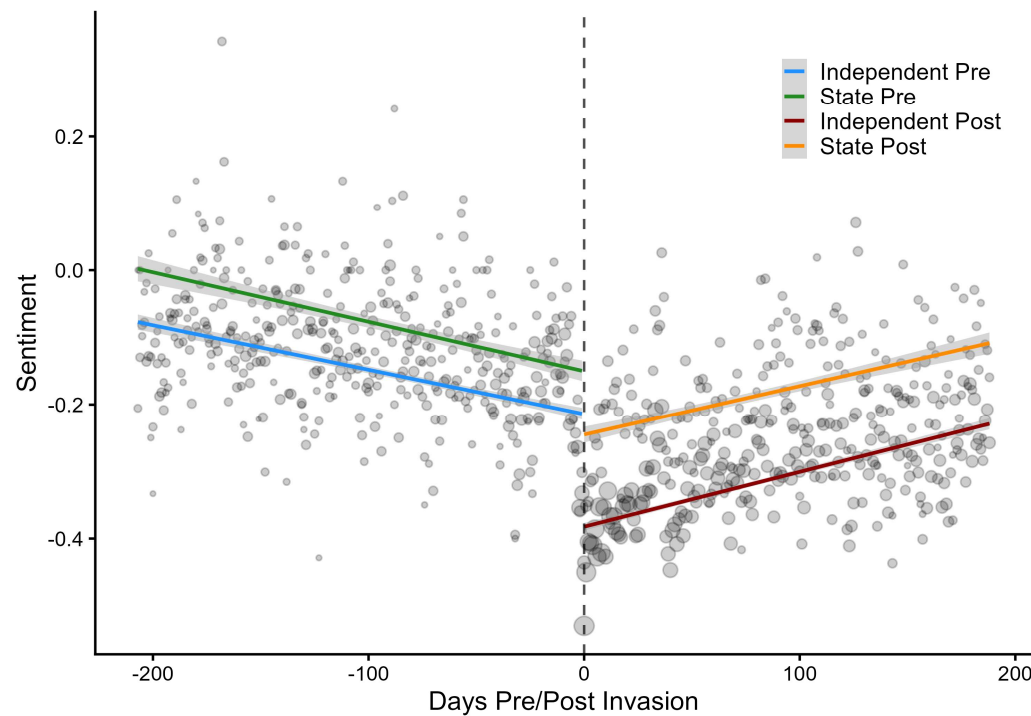
The Shock

The invasion produced a sharp negative shock across all media.



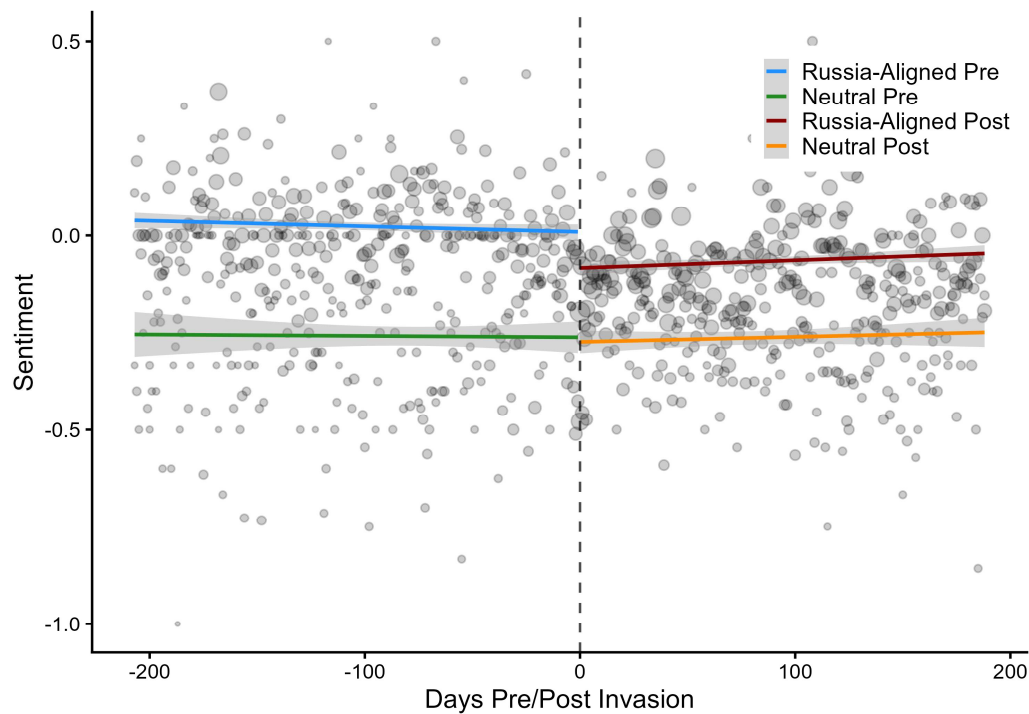
State Media is Different

State media responded less negatively than independent media.



The Counterintuitive Finding

Russia's allies went more negative — not less.



Two Predictions

Domestic Propaganda

Suppress negative coverage to protect the alliance →

Russia-aligned state media should be the *least* negative.

Signaling

Amplify through informal channels because formal ones are locked →

Russia-aligned state media should be the *most* negative.

The data matches the signaling prediction

Beyond International Relations

Constrained communication is universal. Organizations, not just states, signal through informal channels when formal ones are blocked.

The theory-practice gap is a method. Practitioners sit on insights academics haven't formalized — that's a research opportunity in every subfield.

LLMs unlock questions at scale. 174K articles scored by GPT-4o with .92 accuracy — problems that were intractable five years ago are now tractable.

Thank You

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